Do competence-based rewards improve intrinsic motivation in language learning more than participation-based rewards?

Competence-based rewards enhance **intrinsic motivation** when informational, not controlling.

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The scientific consensus indicates that competence-based rewards foster greater intrinsic motivation than pure participation-based rewards when they provide informational feedback, but undermine motivation if perceived as controlling or strictly performance-contingent.

FIGURE 1 Scientific consensus on competence-based rewards versus participation rewards for intrinsic motivation

Informational Feedback Versus Controlling Contingencies

Self-determination theory and cognitive evaluation research show that whether rewards foster intrinsic motivation depends heavily on their functional significance (Xiao & Hew, 2023; Al-Hoorie, 2025; Jedel & Palmquist, 2026). Rewards structured around competence, skill mastery, or meeting absolute performance standards boost perceived self-efficacy and task interest because they supply informational value (Xiao & Hew, 2023; Cameron et al., 2005; Zhou, 2024). In contrast, participation- or completion-contingent rewards primarily serve as behavioral entry points to establish study routines, but they do not inherently elevate feelings of competence (Bardach & Murayama, 2024; Zhou, 2024; Sadik, 2025).

A structural equation modeling analysis of digital language learners using Duolingo confirmed that the informational significance learners attributed to virtual rewards directly enhanced competence satisfaction, which accounted for substantial variance in intrinsic motivation (Jedel & Palmquist, 2026). Furthermore, an experimental trial testing tangible rewards redeemed via mastery points in an online gamified course found that linking rewards to performance standards significantly enhanced students' intrinsic interest and enjoyment compared to baseline points (Xiao & Hew, 2023). Path analyses in achievement settings also demonstrate that perceived competence and interest-internal attribution mediate the positive effects of performance rewards on intrinsic motivation (Cameron et al., 2005).

Crucially, when performance-contingent rewards emphasize evaluation, competition, or stakes, they frequently shift the locus of causality outward and undermine intrinsic drive (Lamb, 2017; Al-Hoorie, 2025). A survey examining 316 language learners revealed a sharp metamotivational mismatch: while students recognized the value of non-controlling positive feedback, they mistakenly believed that competitive and strict performance-contingent rewards would enhance motivation, contrary to empirical evidence highlighting their detrimental controlling effects (Al-Hoorie, 2025).

Theory (with originator)	Pedagogical Implications	Practical Exemplars
Self-determination theory (Deci & Ryan 1985)	Learners will tend to study best when they are intrinsically motivated or have a more internalized kind of motive. To enhance learners' intrinsic motivation, educators need to provide stimulating, satisfying tasks. To help internalize learners' motivation, teachers should provide classroom environments that support their basic need for a sense of autonomy, competence and relatedness (Noels 2013).	*Autonomy* 'Foster relevance, allow criticism, provide choice' (Noels 2013: 27). See Benson (2011) for a review of empirical studies claiming the successful promotion of autonomy. *Competence* Teachers who are perceived as active participants in class, providing useful and encouraging feedback, promote learners' sense of competence (Noels, Clément & Pelletier 1999; Noels 2001). *Relatedness* Express involvement, immediacy and interest (Noels 2013). Develop positive group dynamics (cf. Dörnyei & Murphey 2003).
L2 Motivational self-system (Dörnyei 2009)	Learners can be motivated to study an L2 if they develop strong and elaborate visions of themselves as future users of the L2 (future self-guides), as long as they are plausible, accompanied by action plans, regularly activated and offset by a fear of less desired futures (Dörnyei 2009).	3–4-month programmes are shown to be effective, including: • Goal setting, guided imagery tasks (Magid 2014) • 'Ideal L2 self Tree', visualization exercises, counselling sessions (Chan 2014) • Imaginary class reunion ten years on (Fukuda et al. 2011) • Building imagined communities (Murray 2013; Yashima 2013)
Social cognitive theory (Bandura 1997)	Whether learners feel capable of doing classroom tasks and mastering different features of the L2 will affect their motivation to study. Teachers can enhance learners' self-efficacy through maximizing the chances of success in L2 tasks and providing an emotionally rewarding classroom environment (Mills 2014).	Focused strategy instruction in L2 listening (Graham & Macaro 2008), L2 writing (Mills & Peron 2009), L2 reading (Matsumoto et al. 2013), shown to promote learners' self-efficacy. Also see Erler & Macaro (2011).

Table 3. Prominent theories of motivation applied to language education (Lamb, 2017)
How to read: The table lists prominent psychological theories of motivation applied to language education, detailing their core tenets and typical educational applications.

Motivational Profiles Across Reward Structures

Reward Type	Operational Mechanism	Psychological Need Impact	Intrinsic Motivation Outcome
Competence & Mastery (Xiao & Hew, 2023; Cameron et al., 2005; Zhou, 2024)	Badges or feedback tied to **skill standards** (Xiao & Hew, 2023; Zhou, 2024)	Heightens **perceived competence** and self-efficacy (Xiao & Hew, 2023; Cameron et al., 2005; Jedel & Palmquist, 2026)	Increases **task interest** and enjoyment when non-controlling (Xiao & Hew, 2023; Cameron et al., 2005; Jedel & Palmquist, 2026)
Participation & Completion (Xiao & Hew, 2023; Zhou, 2024)	Incentives for **attendance or logins** (Zhou, 2024; Duisenova & Zhorabekova, 2024)	Satisfies initial **task initiation** needs (Bardach & Murayama, 2024; Duisenova & Zhorabekova, 2024)	Boosts **short-term engagement** without enhancing autonomy (Bardach & Murayama, 2024; Zare et al., 2025)
Performance-Contingent (Al-Hoorie, 2025)	Rewards based on **normative competition** (Lamb, 2017; Al-Hoorie, 2025)	Elicits feelings of **external control** and anxiety (Lamb, 2017; Sadik, 2025)	Decreases **intrinsic drive** and risks shallow learning (Al-Hoorie, 2025; Duisenova & Zhorabekova, 2024)

Reward Type	Operational Mechanism	Psychological Need Impact	Intrinsic Motivation Outcome
Integrated Quests (Philpott & Son, 2022)	Multitiered challenges with **learner choice** (Philpott & Son, 2022; Kashefian-Naeeini et al., 2024)	Fulfills **autonomy and competence** concurrently (Philpott & Son, 2022; Zhou, 2024; Jedel & Palmquist, 2026)	Sustains **long-term persistence** and learning joy (Philpott & Son, 2022; Zhou, 2024; Sadik, 2025)

FIGURE 2 Comparison of reward types and their psychological impacts on second language learners

Mediating Factors in Second Language Learning

- Providing **learner autonomy and choice** mitigates the controlling aspect of rewards, allowing quest-based learning systems to raise intrinsic motivation across foreign language classrooms (Philpott & Son, 2022; Kashefian-Naeeini et al., 2024; Widanta et al., 2024).
- Excessive or **over-attractive extrinsic incentives**, such as monetary rewards in vocabulary competitions, induce imbalanced study behaviors where learners prioritize points over communicative depth (Duisenova & Zhorabekova, 2024; Zhu & Liu, 2022).
- High-performing language learners typically rely on **integrative and intrinsic motives**, whereas low-performing students are disproportionately driven by external instrumental rewards like career advancement or grades (Peng & Fu, 2021; Sadik, 2025; Araya Quesada et al., 2025).
- Blended task environments benefit from **transformative motivation loops**, using completion incentives to spark initial engagement before transitioning to mastery-based internal satisfaction (Bardach & Murayama, 2024; Peng & Fu, 2021; Zhou, 2024; Duisenova & Zhorabekova, 2024; Sadik, 2025).

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